

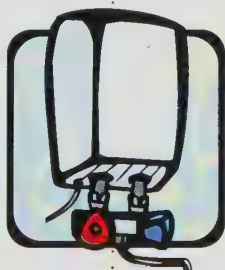
you are not in the home. If nothing else, I like one running in the bathroom first thing in the morning. (It takes the edge off that cold seat, if you know what I mean.)

10. Go to Grandma's

I'm not saying that my house is too cold. Many wouldn't be comfortable in anything as chilly as 55 in October. But on days when I'm not particularly enthusiastic about watching TV in a cooler-than-average home (or once a week), I'll head next door to my mother's house. She's glad to see us, and she has cable. (It's also 10 degrees warmer by default. If she's already paying for gas, why not?)

Call me cheap or stingy, but I don't see any reason to crank up the heat until I really have to. With 35-degree nights turning into almost 70-degree days, starting up my woodstove would leave us baked by midafternoon. These tips help us in the month or two between seasons, keep our annual heating bill low, and help us to appreciate that roaring fire when it finally gets burning each year.

— Linsey Knerl



7 Ways to Lower Water Heater Costs

According to Energy.gov, your water heater can account for 17% of home energy costs. The good news is that there are small, easy tweaks you can make to lower those costs and conserve energy at the same time.

1. Reduce your use

It is usually the shower that keeps most people raising the dial on their water heaters. Use low-flow shower-

heads, take quicker showers, turn off the water when you are soaping up, and stick with mild, lukewarm water. You'll realize you need a lot less hot water than you think.

Also consider using cold water to wash your clothes. About 90% of the energy used in a clothes washer goes to water heating. Cold-water washing also helps clothes last longer!